

# A TRYST WITH THE FUTURE

India is straddled across two worlds—private and public. Last week the Ministry of Finance revealed that the economy grew at an astounding 9.4 per cent, thanks to private consumption and enterprise. It was also the week when we learnt that a teacher had been drawing salary seven years after his death. Private India is speeding into the 21st century while the Government is stuck in the 19th century. The post-1991 R-Generation is flummoxed and frustrated at the state of public services. Governance is trapped in the “muddle path” of central intervention and state responsibility worsened by political expansionism stemming from coalition politics. While political parties are willing to accept fractured verdicts as a consequence of poor governance, they are unwilling to do anything about the cause. To start with,

functions best performed by local governments must be allocated to the states, making the accountability matrix clear. This blueprint has merged 33 ministries into 18, enabling the government to address issues that concern national polity and long-term strategy. When the licence raj was dismantled in 1991, the government triggered a quantum change. Long trapped behind the wall of controls, Indian business used the enabling circumstances to improve productivity, market share and income. If political parties are serious about delivering equity in growth, improving their vote share and the life expectancy of their regimes, they must dismantle the superstructure of pelf. Political parties and institutions resist quantum change as it threatens the status quo. But status quo in the long run will kill the party.

## THE BLUEPRINT

### Prime Minister

The PMO should focus on Atomic Energy, Space, Personnel and ministerial accountability.

### Ministry of Defence

India needs to modernise its forces post-haste and this means more than acquisition of hardware.

### Ministry for Internal Security

With over 191 districts facing law and order crises, focus should be on tackling growing militancy, spread of Naxal influence and insurgency.

### Ministry of Finance

Banking and insurance should be left to regulators; exim policy and corporate affairs must be with MoF.

### Ministry of External Affairs

With growing focus on economic affairs, Commerce should be merged with

MEA. Overseas Indian Affairs should be a strong priority within.

### Ministry for Telecom and IT

Merge them. The telecom boom needs to be extended to rural India and IT should be put to use for e-seva.

### Ministry of Law and Parliamentary Affairs

With over 25 million cases pending, focus should be on beefing up criminal justice. In Parliament focus should be on legislation.

### Ministry for Tourism & Culture

Private participation should be encouraged in tourism and managing the historical legacy.

### Ministry for Health & Family Welfare

Mindset of state-funded healthcare must yield to modern instruments like insurance and public-private partnerships.

### Ministry of Transport

Railways and civil aviation must be merged. The boom in rail and air traffic can be leveraged to fund development of the sectors.

### Ministry for Infrastructure

Shipping, ports and roads can be merged to focus on connectivity for both goods and passenger traffic.

### Ministry for Energy Security

Plans for petroleum, coal and power should be co-ordinated with renewable sources to bridge the gap between energy requirements and availability.

### Ministry of Human Resource Development

There should be focus on opening up the education sector to both outward and inward investment and on creating platforms to develop skills.

### Ministry of Science and Technology

The prowess of public sector institutions should be monetised to get the tech edge and spur growth.

### Ministry for Environment and Earth Sciences

The spectre of climate change and global warming threatens growth, calling for a new blueprint.

### Ministry for Food Security

This would be the omnibus ministry to plan for food security using all avenues including imports, acquiring farmland abroad and strategic reserves.

### Ministry for Rural Development

There is a need to bundle all the functions and schemes of Rural Development and Panchayati Raj and focus on delivery of relief to the poor.